ADHD is one of the worst-named conditions going. It isn't a shortage of attention — it's attention that won't take instructions about where to point.

In plain words

ADHD affects the brain's ability to regulate attention, activity and impulses. Attention isn't missing; it's driven by interest, urgency and novelty rather than by importance. That's why someone can lose six hours to something fascinating and be unable to start a two-minute task they genuinely care about.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Knowing exactly what needs doing, why it matters, and being completely unable to begin.
- Time behaving strangely — five minutes and four hours feeling much the same from the inside.
- Thoughts arriving faster than they can be said, so sentences get interrupted, including your own.
- Emotions landing at full strength immediately, then passing just as fast.
- Hyperfocus, where the world disappears and you forget to eat, drink, or move.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"It's just laziness."	It takes enormous effort to look this disorganised. The wanting was never the problem.
"Only hyperactive boys have it."	Plenty of people are hyperactive only on the inside, and are diagnosed decades late.
"They could focus if they tried."	They can focus, ferociously — just not reliably on demand.
"It's an excuse."	It's an explanation. Those are different things, and only one of them helps.
"Everyone's forgetful."	The difference is scale, consistency, and the cost it exacts over a lifetime.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Ideas nobody else in the room would have had.

Genuinely excellent in a crisis, when urgency finally matches the wiring.

Hyperfocus that produces a month of work in a weekend.

Warmth, humour, and a talent for making things less dull.

Spotting connections between things that appear unrelated.

What actually helps

- ☐ Break tasks into first physical actions
- ☐ Written instructions, not verbal
- ☐ Don't take interruptions personally
- ☐ Put deadlines on things that don't have them
- ☐ Body doubling — work alongside someone
- ☐ Externalise everything: lists, alarms, visible notes

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

"What's the first step? I'll sit with you."

"Shall I send that in a message?"

"Tell me about the thing you're into."

LESS HELPFUL

"Just make a list."

"Everyone's a bit ADHD."

"You managed it last time."

Not a shortage of attention. A different set of rules about where it goes.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk